



Caring for the wounded in wartime

With doctors on the front line overwhelmed, nurses came into their own. During the war, around 2,000 volunteered their services, providing invaluable assistance, and seeing death and disease firsthand.

“[The war] was fought at the end of the **medical Middle Ages.**”

UNION SURGEON GENERAL WILLIAM A. HAMMOND

Staying alive

Although chloroform or whiskey deadened the pain of major surgery, secondary infections caused by ignorance often killed those who had initially lived through the trauma of an operation. Almost one in four amputations resulted in death. Much depended on how quickly the wounded could be evacuated from the field. Soldiers' immune systems and physical strength could better handle the shock of surgery if rapidly treated. After some battles, such as